

Dear Sylvia,

Mémère Couvillion used to say “if you want somebody to hear you, write them a letter.” I hope I have your attention now and that you’re reading what I should’ve said months ago. I know losing Celestine was each of us losing a limb, and we’ve been walking around pretending we’re still whole. But since you pulled away from me, I realized I never stopped to tell you how much I love you, how much you’ve meant to me over the years.

We’re still and always will be the Bywater Babes.

Lately every moment I’m not managing the krewe, I’ve been holed up with hundreds of hours of doc footage-- remember you laughed at me when I mentioned my five-hour cut? Girl, that’s just the tip of the iceberg. Playing and replaying, cutting and recutting, it’s like I’m trying to reassemble who we used to be before Cel’s death broke everything.

There’s one clip I shot a few weeks before the end, the last time I ever interviewed Cel. I think you should watch it. And if and when you do, it will break your heart. It’s clear as day when you watch her: the great Celestine Broussard was scared. It’s like seeing a tiger tremble. As I work on the film, I keep coming back to this moment. There she is, looping over and over on my screen, asking for help that she couldn’t accept.

I know you’re still investigating her death. I guess it helps make sense of her loss, same as editing the doc does for me. But let’s be honest with ourselves. Are either of us going to gain absolution from our penance? Or is it just another way to stay locked up in our own version of reality?

I can’t bear losing you too. I think it’s time to move on, and I include myself in this. Maybe we could both try to take a break from reconstructing the past and let Celestine rest? I know that’s what she would have wanted.

Your sister forever,

Ines